Understanding and using feedback

Practical guide for students | D12-ST

Feedback becomes useful when you understand it and use it to change your work or approach. Look for strengths to keep using as well as specific improvements to make.

1. Find all the feedback

Check the rubric, comments on your work, summary feedback and any relevant class feedback. Read these alongside the task requirements rather than looking only at the grade.

2. Work out what the comment means

Identify the passage, calculation or decision the comment refers to. Distinguish issues with subject understanding, evidence, organisation and language. Ask if a term such as “develop” is unclear.

3. Identify priorities

Choose one or two changes that will make a meaningful difference. Notice recurring comments across tasks. Keep a note of strengths so you can repeat successful choices.

4. Ask for a concrete clarification

Show the relevant section and explain your interpretation: “Does ‘more analysis’ mean explaining why these figures support my recommendation?” Ask what to practise rather than requesting a complete corrected answer.

5. Make and practise a change

Revise a short section or try a similar problem, even if you cannot resubmit the original task. Check whether your change addresses the feedback and preserves the intended meaning.

6. Use the learning again

Before your next assignment, review your action points. Apply those that fit the new task and check your progress. A different task may require a different approach.

7. Example

The feedback says your recommendation needs stronger justification. You identify where you listed advantages without connecting them to the decision. You revise one paragraph to explain why the evidence favours your chosen option, then use this as a reminder when planning the next assignment.

8. Quick checklist

☐ I have read the comments and rubric.

☐ I can explain the main feedback in my own words.

☐ I have chosen specific actions.

☐ I will check these actions in my next task.

9. When to seek further support

Ask your teacher to clarify feedback about subject knowledge or marking criteria. Academic skills or language support can help you practise the relevant skills. If you believe a result contains an error, check the institution's review procedure and deadlines separately.

10.Supporting sources

Monash University. (n.d.). Learn from feedback. Student Academic Success. Open resource

Supports interpreting different forms of feedback, identifying patterns, making an action plan and applying feedback to future learning.

RMIT University. (n.d.). Rubrics and learning outcomes. Learning Lab. Open resource

Supports using criteria and performance descriptions to understand expectations.